Grease the groove: your first two weeks

Mission: 20 strict pull-ups, non-stop. Today: 8.

> **Today's win:** do your first *groove set* of 4 strict pull-ups, then log it. That's the whole plan in miniature.

The idea in one breath

Pull-ups get better when you practise them **often** and **fresh**, not when you grind them to exhaustion. Pavel Tsatsouline calls this "greasing the groove": many sub-maximal sets spread through the day, never to failure, so you're "training as often as possible while being as fresh as possible."[1] Small sets need little recovery, which is why you can repeat them many times a day.[2] In Pavel's article, a 60-year-old who did chin-ups every time he went to the basement went on to do 20.[1]

That fits you well: each set takes about 30 seconds, and you don't have to change clothes for it.

Your two-week plan

Day	What
Mon–Fri	**Groove sets**: 4 strict reps (half your max of 8). Do 4–6 sets, at least an hour apart. Daily total: 16–24 reps.
Sat	Optional: 2–3 groove sets if you feel fresh. Otherwise rest.
Sun	Rest. Armstrong's program also takes two days off from pull-ups each week.[3]
Week 2	If week 1 felt easy, go to 6 sets a day, or do 5 reps on your first two sets.
Wed Oct 28	**Test**: warm up with 2 easy reps, rest 3 minutes, then do one strict max set. Skip groove sets that day.

Rules for a groove set

- Strict form: start from a dead hang, get your chin over the bar, and don't kip. Armstrong says quality matters more than numbers.[3]
- Stop each set while every rep still moves at the same speed. If a rep slows down, the set was too big.
- Stay well away from failure. Pavel warns that going to exhaustion burns you out.[1]
- If your elbows or shoulders hurt, take 2 days off and then go back to smaller sets.
- Missed a day? Don't make it up. Just do the next day as planned.

Why there's a test: one trainee found GTG alone stalled him, and regular max tests plus harder days helped him break through.[4] Lesson 2 will add Armstrong-style structure after your Oct 28 test.

Log today

Check yourself

1. Your max is 8. How big is one groove set?

- 6 reps
- 4 reps
- 8 reps

2. When does a groove set end?

- well before any struggle
- at first failed rep
- after last slow rep

3. How far apart should groove sets be?

- five minutes apart
- fifteen minutes apart
- about an hour apart

4. Your elbow aches midweek. What do you do?

- push through the ache
- rest it, then reduce
- add more daily sets

Read this

Primary source: The Armstrong Pull-up Program, a two-page PDF from the USMC written for exactly your goal of 20 reps. Read it now, because it's what you'll follow after week 2. Background: Pavel's original GTG article.

Anything unclear? Want the sets moved around your workday? **Ask your teacher.** Just message me in chat. Text me your daily totals, and send your test number on Oct 28.

Sources: [1] Tsatsouline, "Grease the Groove for Strength" (reprint). [2] Fitness Stack Exchange Q&A 3448. [3] Armstrong Pull-up Program, USMC OSO PDF. [4] r/bodyweightfitness, "My Long Journey to 20 Pullups."